

IN LIEU OF A SYNOPSIS (harper)

I could write neat and clear, without so many nooks and crannies, so much useless pinwheeling. I could write almost telegraphically for the whole world and for the symmetrical ratification of all languages kowtowed to English. I'll never write in English; with any luck I say, Go home. I could write a doorstopper of a novel with weighty silences and an elaborate plot; I could write the silence of the Dao with its fastidiousness for the precise word, while stuffing my adjectives under a disciplined tongue. I could write with no tongue, like a newscaster on CNN, no accent and hold the salt. But my tongue is salted and the syllables, rather than correcting me, they sing. I could write to correct, to pass on knowledge, so that my mess of a tongue might learn to sit down and be quiet. I could write with my legs crossed and buttocks tight, with Sufi yearning and the Orient's economy of language. I could improve my language, shoving every last corroded metaphor up my ass, along with my stinking desires and hysterical mind full of Mary Lou or Marry AIDS, with no parasol or with my umbrella propped upside down, right in the sun so that I go global, exportable, translated even into Greek, which sings to me about as much as a blossoming fart. I could hide away the ire and plumed rage of my images, the violence enacted by violence, and sleep peacefully with my romantic fantasies. But that's not who I am—I concocted my name with the milonga drag of a travestango starlet, a faggy cueca or hard rock bolero. I could report on the high life and come to regret my coarse and lurid

subject matter. Leave the rabble-rousing to the rabble and dig through Hispanic etymology instead. But that's not why I came. The world is full of writers with fountain pens staining flowers into the miserly buttonholes of their lapels. I didn't come to sing ladies and gentlemen ; but all the same I do sing, my dear señora. I don't know why I showed up at this concert, but here I am. And the verses flew from me like a knife. But not really verses, just my hand drawing out the growl, the sob. Like the screech of a cowardly bitch, certain writers hissed from the right wing of the stage. I came to writing with no love for it, I was heading somewhere else, I wanted to sing protest songs, fly on the trapeze, or be an Indian bird trilling at the dusk. But my tongue curled up in impotence and instead of clarity or studied emotion I emitted a jungle of sounds. I wasn't musical, I wasn't singing within earshot of higher powers so they'd remember me at the right hand of neoliberal heaven. My father wondered why they paid me to write while nobody rewarded him for the

effort. And I did learn by effort, I learned already grown, just like Paquita la del Barrio. Writing didn't come easy to me. I wanted to sing and they clubbed me with rules. I learned clawing my way through onomatopoeia, dieresis, intonation, and the big knockers of grammar and spelling. But so many rules were bad for me, so many crosswords of thought, and I forgot it all instantly. I learned out of hunger, out of necessity, from working at it, from pimping myself, but I began to feel sad. I could've written like the others and in a style that was beautiful and clear, as clear as the water that runs through Patagonia's rivers. But the city did me wrong, mistreated me, and sex drew its X and spat on my sphincter. I say that I could, but really I couldn't have—I lacked rigor, and getting fucked up won out, the sordid charm of love lied. And like an idiot I believed, like a drooping skank I hoodwinked with baroque allegories and nonsense that sounded real nice. You could've been someone else, the teachers told me, drool staining their haircloths. Despite everything I did learn, but sadness fell on me like a cloak. I said I wasn't a singer and that's true, but music was the only technicolor in my tipsy biography. And here's the staff where

the story lurches out its tragic rhythms. Like it or not, I'll press play on this last collection of songs.

A Kind of Synopsis

By Sergio Holas-Véliz, Israel Holas Allimant and Pedro Lemebel

I could write clearly, I could write without so many nooks and crannies, without so many useless twists and turns. I could write telegraphically for the globe, symmetrically, in order to appease the languages that have submitted and kneeled to English. I'll never write in English, with any luck I can say *go home*. I could write novels and great tomes full of rational stories and symbolic silences. I could write in the silence of *Tao*, with the sumptuousness of choosing the correct words and I could also keep the adjectives under my tongue. I could write with no tongue, like a host on CNN, bluntly and without accent. But my tongue is sharp and my vocal chords choose to sing, instead of educating. I could write in order to educate, to give knowledge, so that the *babel* that is my tongue might learn to sit, without uttering a word. I could write with my legs together, with cheeks firmly closed, with a Sufi push and an oriental economy of language. I could better language by sticking my corroded metaphors, my stinking desires and my confusing and gay head up my ass, without a sunshade or with my umbrella, in reverse, and I could do this in full daylight, so that globalisation could make me go worldwide, exportable, and translatable even in Aramaic, even if it sounds like a flowery fart. I could keep my ire and the plumed¹ rage of my images to myself, feed the violence back into itself and sleep well, content with my cheesy stories. But that's not my name. I invented a name for myself, one that sticks, and sounds like a gay-tango, rock-bolero or a transvestite-showgirl. I could be the chronicler of the *high life* and regret the hard to swallow nature of my writing. I could leave the riff-raff for the riff-raff and instead become an archaeologist of the Spanish language. But I didn't come here to do that. The world is already full of writers that wear suits and ties and come equipped with flowery fountain-pens in their miserly breast-pockets. I didn't come here to sing, *ladies and gentleman*; but I sing anyway. I don't know how I got here, but here I am. And my language emerged like a stiletto, without words, like an extension of my hand, a growl or a cry. They sound like the cries of a cowardly woman, said the writers from the right wing soap opera. I came to writing without wanting it, I was going elsewhere. I wanted to be a singer, a trapeze artist, or an Indian-bird trilling at the sunset. But my tongue curled-up out of impotence, and instead of clarity or refined emotion, I produced a jungle of noise. I did not sing in the sweet sounds of rhyme, nor did I sing to the ear of transcendence in order to be at the right-hand of the gods of this neoliberal paradise. My father would ask himself, why do they pay you to write, when no one had ever payed him for his efforts. I learnt it by force. I learnt to write as a grown-up. Like Paquita la del Barrio² says; writing was not easy for me. I wanted to sing, but was battered with grammar. Strike after strike, I learnt onomatopoeia, diaeresis, the art of composition, and the big breasted rules of orthography. But I forgot it all quickly, so many rules made me ill, like so many crosswords of written thought. I learnt out of hunger, out of necessity, out of the need to work, to become like a pimp. But I had started to become sad. I could have had nice handwriting and written like a well- educated person, with clear writing, clear like that of the water that runs in the rivers of the south. But the city was bad to me, the streets mistreated me, and sex spat on my sphincter. I say I could have, but I know that I couldn't. I lacked rigor and was won over by drowsiness and the sordid appeal of the lies of love. And I believed like a fool, like a wilted dog I let myself be swindled by baroque allegories and word games that sounded so very beautiful. I could have been different, my teachers said, drooling all over their prophet-like hairs. Despite everything, I learnt, but sadness fell over me like a veil. I didn't become a singer, I tell you, but music was the only spot of Technicolor in my unsettled biography. Here goes

this pentagram, where the story danced to its own tragic rhythm. Whether you like it or not, here I press play and let loose this songbook of memories.

1. *Tener pluma*: a Spanish language expression that refers to the gay nature of a person's sexuality. It literally translates as 'to be feathered'. Here Lemebel is referencing his own identification as gay. ↩
2. The stage name of a popular Mexican singer of *rancheras* and other traditional Mexican and Latin American songs. Her lyrics are strongly feminist and ironic in their rejection of the stereotypes of masculinity. ↩